

DVD Burning

Lots of people have started buying DVD-Writers, but problems abound

Robert Sovereign-Smith

Making the *Digit* DVD every month, we come across problems we never knew existed. Some we're able to solve, some just leave us perplexed. We also get a lot of questions from our readers. Let's take a look at a few.

Problem: The drive says it can burn at 16x, yet if a DVD is burnt at anything above 4x, the drive spits out a coaster.

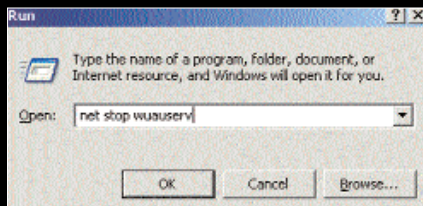
Solution: This sounds a little like the following joke:

Patient: Doctor, it hurts when I do this.
Doctor: Well, don't do that then!

The simplest solution is to burn at slower speeds. The problem is generally caused by bottlenecks in your hardware—a slow CPU, older and slower hard drive or too little RAM can cause problems when burning at higher speeds. Yes, new generation drives are supposed to use error correction and caching to avoid producing coffee-cup coasters, but they're only machines! You can't seriously expect a drive to burn at 16x on a system configuration of a 700 MHz CPU, a 5400 rpm hard drive and 256 MB of SD RAM. 1x would be the safest option in this case!

Problem: This actually happened when we were burning the current month's *Digit* DVD master! The Windows XP Auto-Update feature rebooted the computer when no one was looking, and there was a DVD being written!

Solution: There are quite a few solutions to this problem, and none of them involve the DVD drive or your burning software. It's a Windows problem. There are two types of reboot warning bugs that appear—the one that asks for a confirmation and pops up every 10 minutes, and the one that automatically reboots in five minutes. Both are just as deadly, because if you are typing something when the first one pops up, hitting [Enter] or [Y] will reboot your computer, and you will lose anything you didn't save—DVDs or CDs currently being burnt will be of no use except to adorn auto-rickshaw rear-view mirrors! The



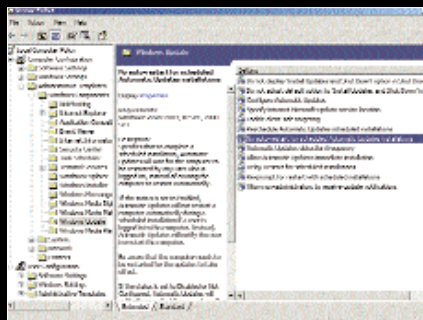
Run the "net stop wuauaserv" command to stop the Windows Update service

second one is the one that will reboot your system automatically, so leaving your system unattended when burning discs is a no-no.

You could just turn off the Auto-Update feature, but then you might miss out on something critical. We don't recommend this.

You can temporarily disable the restart option by going to Start > Run, and typing in "net stop wuauaserv". This is a good temporary solution, as it enables the Windows Update service at next reboot. This solution is the only choice Windows XP Home users have.

Windows XP Professional users can use the Group Policy Editor: go to Start > Run, type in "gpedit.msc" and press [Enter]. Find your way to Local Computer Policy > Computer Configuration > Administrative Templates > Windows Components > Windows Update. Here you will see many options that should be self-explanatory. The most important ones are: "No auto-restart for schedule Automatic Updates installations", which can be set to "Enabled", or set "Re-prompt for restart with scheduled installations" to something like



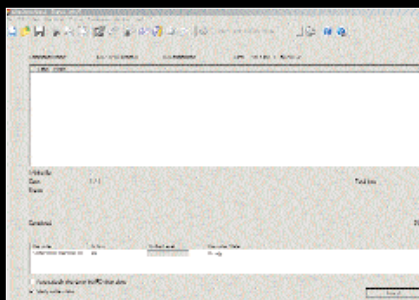
You can permanently disable the restart feature

1440 minutes (24 hours). Now you can leave your computer unattended while burning DVDs or CDs.

Problem: You use your DVD drive to back up important system data. Even though you burnt the data successfully, you find a lot of it is corrupt when trying a restore.

Solution: This problem is common with older DVD-Writers. As the lens gets dirtier and the laser weaker, errors start to creep in to your discs. Burning a DVD with Nero, you might see the "Burn completed successfully" message and think all is well, but this isn't always the case.

The problem lies either in an underpowered system, or a faulty DVD drive. Try and close all other applications when burning a DVD. If your computer has been on for a long time, turn it off for 15 minutes and then start it. Then end all unnecessary applications and burn the DVD. If you are on a network and have a lot of frequently accessed shared folders, you might want



Check the "Verify Written Data" checkbox

to disable the network connection while you burn.

For important data, it is imperative that you check "Verify Written Data", which is at the bottom left when you start the burning process. This function is available on all major DVD or CD burning software, but may be named differently. What this option does is match the data written on the DVD, byte by byte, with the data on the hard drive that you burn. If the data verification succeeds, you have successfully written the DVD without corruption. ■

robert_smith@thinkdigit.com